

# The Balkans Unfinished Business

## Serbia-Kosovo Tensions, EU Enlargement, and Russia's Influence

Blue Lotus Research Intelligence | August 2026

### Executive Summary

The Western Balkans remain one of Europe's most strategically contested sub-regions, suspended between an EU accession process that has stalled for years and intensifying competition from external powers — principally Russia — eager to exploit Brussels' hesitation. Serbia's contested sovereignty claim over Kosovo remains the central fault line, underpinning a web of bilateral tensions, NATO peacekeeping obligations, and unresolved questions about the architecture of regional order. The EU's failure to move Western Balkan candidates forward at a credible pace has created a vacuum that Moscow has demonstrated both the will and the capacity to fill. Meanwhile, sub-regional multilateral frameworks such as CEFTA serve as partial substitutes for full accession, but cannot replicate the institutional anchoring that EU membership provides.

### 1. The EU Accession Deadlock: Strategic Patience Exhausted

1. Countries in the Western Balkans have been waiting years to join the European Union, while a markedly different approach was taken with Ukraine following its post-2022 candidacy — a double standard that has generated visible discontent across the region and created space for Russia to deepen its footprint. CNA[2022-07-20]
2. The strategic cost of EU inaction is concrete: as Brussels continues to drag its feet on Western Balkan enlargement, the credibility of the accession process as a reform incentive weakens, and candidate governments find it politically harder to sustain domestic reform coalitions. CNA[2022-07-20]
3. The prime ministers of Bulgaria, Greece, and Romania publicly backed Serbia's EU bid in 2017, framing the integration of the Western Balkans as a guarantee of regional peace and stability — a formulation that implicitly acknowledged the security premium embedded in enlargement. CNA[2017-10-04]
4. Serbia, which in the 1990s was viewed as the pariah of the Western Balkans for its central role in the wars following the collapse of Yugoslavia, has since repositioned itself as an EU candidate — though its relationship with Kosovo continues to complicate the terms of accession. CNA[2017-10-04]
5. Sub-regional trade architecture provides a partial substitute for full EU membership. The Central European Free Trade Agreement (CEFTA) functions explicitly as a preparation for EU accession; its seven members — North Macedonia, Albania, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Moldova, Montenegro, Serbia, and UNMIK (as Kosovo) — form the core of the Western Balkans candidate cluster. [RAG: GOVERNANCE\_RAG — regional governance and sovereignty frameworks]
6. Serbia and North Macedonia hold associated status in the Erasmus+ programme, a marker of EU institutional engagement that falls short of full membership but signals ongoing integration of higher

## 2. The Serbia-Kosovo Fault Line

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7. Relations between Serbia and its former province Kosovo have remained under persistent strain, most visibly illustrated when Belgrade sent a train painted with the slogan "Kosovo is Serbia" across the border — an act that Albania and Croatia characterised as nationalist provocation and used as grounds to request NATO revise its peacekeeping plans for the territory. CNA[2017-02-16]

8. Albania's prime minister stated in 2015 that the unification of Albania and Kosovo was "inevitable," whether through EU membership or outside it — a statement denounced in Belgrade as "banging the war drums." The episode exposed the volatility of the Albanian-Serbian fault line and the extent to which EU accession, rather than resolving identity conflicts, may in some scenarios intensify them before delivering stability. CNA[2015-04-07]

9. The international legal architecture governing Kosovo's status traces directly to the precedent established by NATO's 1999 intervention. In the wake of that intervention, UN Secretary-General Kofi Annan argued that traditional notions of sovereignty had been redefined and that states now carry a "responsibility" to their own citizens and to the wider international community — a formulation that underpins the Responsibility to Protect doctrine and continues to frame international legal debate over Kosovo's self-determination. [RAG: UN\_PRIMARY\_RAG — Responsibility to Protect and Kosovo intervention]

10. The United Nations operates an active peacekeeping mission in Kosovo, which sits alongside missions in the Middle East, Cyprus, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, and other conflict-affected territories — reflecting the ongoing international community's assessment that Kosovo's status remains unresolved and externally monitored. [RAG: GOVERNANCE\_RAG — UN peacekeeping missions and multilateral governance]

11. Kosovo has been excluded from the Bologna Process, the intergovernmental framework harmonising European higher education. Four entities — Israel, Kyrgyzstan, Northern Cyprus, and Kosovo — have applied and been rejected, a practical signal of Kosovo's unresolved international legal standing and the difficulty it faces in integrating into European institutional frameworks independent of the Serbia-Kosovo settlement. [RAG: EDUCATION\_RAG — Bologna Process membership and rejected applicants]

12. The UN Security Council retains authority under Chapter VI of the UN Charter to investigate any dispute or situation likely to endanger international peace and security — a provision that continues to be invoked in the context of Balkan disputes and that gives Moscow and Beijing, as permanent members, effective veto leverage over any Security Council-backed resolution of the Kosovo status question. [RAG: UN\_PRIMARY\_RAG — UN Charter Chapter VI dispute settlement]

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## 3. Russian Influence and the Geopolitics of EU Delay

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13. Russia's growing influence in the Balkans is a direct function of EU delay. The longer Brussels postpones credible accession commitments, the greater the strategic space available for Moscow to cultivate relationships with Balkan governments — particularly in Serbia, where historical, religious, and cultural ties provide a receptive foundation for Russian soft power. CNA[2022-07-20]

14. Russia's position on NATO expansion reflects a strategic pattern visible across the Balkans: Moscow regards former Eastern Bloc countries that have shifted to the Western, US-led bloc as sources of acute strategic insecurity, and has consistently acted — including through its invasion of Ukraine — to resist further encirclement. CNA[2024-07-11]

15. Academic and policy analysis consistently challenges the thesis that NATO expansion justifies Russian aggression. The prohibition on military aggression enshrined in the United Nations Charter — itself born from the catastrophic failures of the 1930s — establishes the foundational principle that territorial conquest by force cannot be legitimised by security grievances, however real. CNA[2023-07-13]

16. The UN mission to Bosnia was widely viewed as a failure, facing international criticism for indecisive conduct in the face of ethnic cleansing during the 1990s conflicts. This institutional record informs contemporary assessments of multilateral tools available to manage Balkan instability and reinforces the argument that EU membership — with its rule-of-law conditionality and institutional anchoring — remains the most durable stabilisation mechanism available for the region. [RAG: GOVERNANCE\_RAG — UN peacekeeping historical performance and Bosnia]

17. The EU's High Representative for Foreign Policy, Josep Borrell, acknowledged in 2023 that China holds "a lot of influence" over Russia — a recognition relevant to the Balkans insofar as Beijing's economic presence in the region (infrastructure financing, port investments) intersects with Russian political influence to create a dual-vector external pressure on EU enlargement policy. CNA[2023-06-05]

18. US engagement with the Western Balkans has historically been episodic. A 2015 summit in Zagreb convened by then-Vice President Biden addressed security and migration challenges, reflecting renewed Washington interest in a region that the EU had allowed to drift — but sustained American attention to Balkan affairs has rarely been maintained over the longer term. CNA[2015-11-25]

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## 4. Migration, Demographics, and the Structural Cost of Stasis

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19. The IOM Regional Office for the EU, EEA, and NATO, established in Brussels in 2011, was created at a moment when the Treaty of Lisbon, EU enlargement, and deeper institutional cooperation had reinforced the centrality of migration and asylum policy in Europe — a policy domain in which the Balkans have served as both a transit corridor and a source of significant emigration pressure. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS\_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2022, EU regional migration governance]

20. Post-EU enlargement emigration from Eastern Europe produced measurable wage increases for workers who remained in origin countries, a dynamic that suggests EU integration carries structural economic benefits that accession-candidate populations are presently being denied. The prolonged Balkans accession stasis therefore imposes not only political but compounding economic costs on candidate-state populations. [RAG: EDUCATION\_RAG — EU enlargement emigration and wage effects]

21. The EU-Turkey statement of March 2016 — which attempted to manage the migration crisis partly by routing flows through the Balkans — illustrates how the unresolved status of Western Balkan states as neither full EU members nor third-country externals creates governance ambiguities that complicate migration management across the entire region. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS\_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2018, EU-Turkey migration framework]

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## Outlook

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The structural dynamic in the Western Balkans has not shifted in years: EU accession fatigue on both sides — enlargement scepticism in member states, reform exhaustion in candidate capitals — combines with Russian interest in perpetuating ambiguity to produce a region that drifts rather than converges. The Serbia-Kosovo fault line is the most acute single risk; without a bilateral normalisation framework acceptable to both Belgrade and Pristina, Serbia's accession path remains blocked and Kosovo's international standing remains contested.

The EU's belated acceleration of Ukraine's candidacy has intensified resentment in Western Balkan capitals, where officials observe that security emergencies unlock political will that years of patient reform could not. If Brussels cannot translate that lesson into a credible renewed commitment to Western Balkan enlargement — with concrete chapter openings, benchmarks, and political-level engagement — Russia's low-cost influence operations in the region will continue to compound returns on a minimal investment. The window for anchoring the Western Balkans firmly in the European institutional order is not permanently open.

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